

We installed both the KDE and GNOME environments to see how each one behaved. Applications took noticeably longer to start up with KDE than with GNOME. This was with 256 MB of RAM on a P4 2.6 GHz machine. But upping the RAM to 512 MB saw the difference in response time almost disappear.

Hardware is well-supported on Fedora Core 4. ATi and nVidia, the two largest video card makers today, have their cards supported. A variety of monitor models are also recognised, and the display is adjusted accordingly. Support for card readers is also inbuilt, with the auto-mount feature. However, it would have been great if Windows partitions, at least on the same hard disk as Fedora, would auto-mount too. Perhaps we're asking for too much!

Being a developer and enthusiast-oriented release, Fedora is scheduled for release every four to six months, while the more stable and tested Red Hat is projected for upgrades every year or longer. The biggest advantage you have with Fedora is the seemingly infinite number of applications written to run on it. The rpm (Red Hat Package Manager) format is more or less the default standard adopted in distributing applications. Even SuSE has agreed to support the rpm format. Installing applications is a matter of just one command, making it very friendly for a newbie.

In terms of features and customisability, we would say Fedora leaves little to be desired. You can spend hours just customising your machine without doing any work! The biggest plus point for Fedora must be the availability of a vast pool of applications that can be installed besides the bundled ones.

Trivia

There has been some conflict over the use of the name "Fedora." Originally, it was the name given to an academic project that was underway at Cornell University in association with the University of Virginia for the former's digital library in 1997. At that time, FEDORA stood for Flexible Extensible Digital Object and Repository Architecture. It was released for public use first as Fedora Release 1.0 in May 2003.